

A Question of SURVIVAL

In his third book on Pakistan, Tariq Ali urges the country to break free of the US satrapy if it wants to live to tell the tale

| By Brahma Chellaney |

At a time when Pakistan is sinking, with its economy tottering on the brink of bankruptcy and its Talibanisation spreading, the book raises fundamental questions about that country's direction. The London-based Tariq Ali is anything but optimistic about Pakistan's ability to come to grips with its existential challenges. Ali's first book on the country had prophetically predicted its break-up just two years before East Pakistan seceded. His second study, published during General Zia-ul-Haq's rule, was titled, "Can Pakistan Survive?", prompting Islamabad to do what it did with his first book—ban it. Now, in his third book, Ali raises the tantalising question: whether Pakistan can be "recycled"? By that he means whether there could be a social and political revival in "a land of perpetual dictatorships and corrupt politicians".

More than six decades after it was created, Pakistan has gone from being a regional concern to being a threat to international security. Today, Pakistan is disparaged as a "Problemistan", "Terroristan" and "Al Qaidistan", with outgoing US President George W. Bush calling it "wilder than the Wild West". By setting up state-run terrorist complexes, it became its own enemy—and victim. The military's domination of the country, which Ali repeatedly brings out, has been shaken but not shrunk with the installation of a civilian government following elections that the author says "were cautiously rigged to deny any

single party an overall majority". The book, however, is largely about America's interventionist role in Pakistan that has helped create a "US-backed politico-military elite" out of sync with the masses. His thesis is that Pakistan's problems today "are a direct result of doing Washington's bidding in previous decades". To be sure, US policies have helped fatten the very institution that constitutes the core problem—the Pakistan military. Because the US is distant, they thought the fallout of their policies would be largely confined to the region. Then came the blowback from 9/11 and the subsequent events. As Ali reminds his readers, the US-brokered deal with Benazir Bhutto was really designed to help the despotic Pervez Musharraf stay on as President. The continuing supply of offensive, India-directed weapon systems shows that US policy remains wedded to the Pakistani military because it

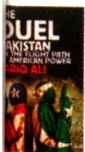
employs the country as a gateway to combat operations in Afghanistan, a potential base against Iran and a vehicle for other geopolitical objectives.

But can all of Pakistan's ills be blamed on USA's policy? The book is less clear on that score. In its 61-year history, Pakistan has already had four military takeovers and four Constitutions. Ali argues that Pakistan needs to break free from US "satrapy". But the next US President is likely to pursue a more activist Pakistan policy. Political expediency will continue to guide US policy, not long-term considerations. India will be left to bear the brunt of an enduringly Talibanised Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Ali, as a gutsy, forthright writer, has written an engrossing account of Pakistan's travails. The book's main failing is its poor structure with some sections disjointed and arguments rambling. Besides better editing, it could have benefited from fact-checking to eliminate mistakes like the "1959 India-China war". Yet, it will rank as one of the most objective accounts of Pakistan's troubled history.



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GEORGE BUSH WITH
FORMER PAKISTAN
PRESIDENT PERVEZ
MUSHARRAF (RIGHT)



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